

Inside Ayako's Place: Malacca's Private Dinner of Food, Memory and Poetry

In a shophouse near Jonker Street, a reservation-only dinner becomes an intimate encounter with food, old photographs, poetry and the quiet art of being received.

By WU Jiaqian

MALACCA, MALAYSIA — There is a door on a back lane off Jonker Street that is easy to miss.

It is narrow, set into the face of a shophouse near the city's historic core. There is no sign. No menu posted in the window. No queue. Guests find it the way they find most things worth finding — through someone who has already been changed by it.

Walk up the stairs. And then stop.

The room is less a dining room than a life made visible. Books line every wall — shipped from Japan at considerable expense, arranged in double rows so deep you cannot see what is behind what. On the shelves between them: a bronze Buddha rescued from a roadside temple, a carved wooden mask, a camera obscura demonstration kit, framed photographs of people long dead. Six cats move through it all with the authority of long tenure, weaving around chair legs and ankles, indifferent to whoever has arrived this time.

At the centre of the room, a round table. A small vase of fresh flowers. Cutlery that is over a hundred years old.



The hidden entrance to Ayako's Place near Jonker Street

A private table in a tourist city

Malacca draws millions of visitors each year, a number that has turned much of its UNESCO-listed historic core into a choreography of trishaw rides, Instagram stops and near-identical souvenir stalls. The night market along

the river fills nightly with crowds, the air thick with the smell of grilled corn and sugarcane juice. It is possible to spend three days in this city and leave having encountered nothing that wasn't designed for you to encounter.

Ayako's Place is the opposite of all of that.

It is a private dining table — one sitting per session, two sessions a day at most, never more than seven guests at a time — run out of the upstairs living quarters of a shophouse by a retired Japanese-American couple who have lived here for fourteen years and show no signs of leaving. The price is fifty-five ringgit, roughly twelve US dollars, for five to eight courses. The hosts are in their seventies and eighties. Business, Ayako says, is quiet.

And yet the guests who find their way here tend to stay for three hours and leave quietly stunned.



The upstairs dining room, filled with books, flowers and memories

The people behind the table

Peter is eighty years old this year. He carries the fact the way he carries everything — lightly, with a kind of amused wonder at how it happened so quickly. He was a professor of Japanese film culture at Nagoya University, and at others before that, and before that a young man from the American Midwest who found himself moving through the world and kept moving. He ended up here, in this shophouse on this back lane, because — as he tells it — the current slowed down, and the water was warm, and his wife Ayako said: this is good.

That was fourteen years ago. They have not left.

Ayako is from Hokkaido, the northernmost island of Japan, where winters are long and summers feel like a gift. She studied Japanese literature, then sociology for her master's degree, then somewhere along the way became a poet — which is not a career so much as a condition. She writes about rain and pineapples and the particular way afternoon light falls on the river. She taught Japanese to foreigners for years and wrote columns about Malacca's history for magazines in Japan. She says she knows this city, by now, better than many people born here.

Together, three years ago, they opened Ayako's Place. The idea was simple: cook what they cooked at home, tell the stories they had always told, and see who came.



Ayako and Peter at their private table. Photo courtesy of Ayako

Food as an invitation

The food arrives without announcement and without apology for being what it is: home cooking, Japanese in its bones, shaped by decades of living elsewhere. A skewer of grilled chicken, the meat tender enough to silence a table. A small dish of pickled apple — sweet and sharp, the kind of thing a guest reaches for a second helping of before finishing the first. Miso soup made from scratch. A Japanese curry rice that is gentle in the way that only very confident cooking can be.

Ayako sits at the corner of the table during the meal. She explains each dish with the casual precision of someone who has thought carefully about everything she does — this technique learned from a food magazine, that one adapted from memory, another invented because she had the ingredients and an instinct. She says "omakase" means "I leave it to you," or more exactly, "please take care of me." She says the best meal is one where the guest can fully relax.

She refills the tea before anyone notices it has gone cold.



Ayako's home-style Japanese dinner

A wooden box of memory

Peter, meanwhile, has disappeared. He returns — this is the ritual, though first-time guests do not yet know it — carrying a wooden box. It is about the size of a book, hinged like a locket, covered in leather that has cracked and softened over nearly two centuries. He sets it on the table, and the dinner shifts into something else entirely.

Inside the box is a daguerreotype: a photograph made on glass in the 1840s, framed in nine-karat gold, cushioned in velvet flattened by age. A woman in the fashion of her era. Oval frame, as was the tradition then. Her name, Peter says, was Laura Monroe. She was his great-great-grandmother.

He has four of these boxes. He brings them all out, one by one.

There is a baby held by someone whose head is cut from the top of the frame — the mother, Peter explains, who did not matter to the image because the image was made to record the child, because children died then with a frequency that people now can barely imagine, and a photograph was an insurance against forgetting. There is a boy of nine named Charlie Monroe, dressed in Scottish clothes, cheeks lightly tinted by a studio girl hired for her steady hand. By the morning this photograph was taken, Peter says, Charlie had been in bed with tuberculosis for six months.

The room goes quiet. Not the quiet of discomfort, but of attention.

Peter does not perform the story. He tells it carefully, with respect for its weight. He explains how the daguerreotype man would have carried his bulky equipment up the stairs, how Charlie would have been dressed in his Sunday clothes and held still by a metal clamp behind his head, how the exposure took five and a half minutes, how the studio girls would paint the irises back into eyes that had blinked. He has been a professor for most of his adult life. He knows how to hold a room.

Then he picks up the box and passes it around the table — and the guests hold it over the tablecloth and look at Charlie Monroe, age nine, whose great-great-great-something is now eighty years old in a shophouse in Malacca, still holding his memory up to the light.



Peter's box of nineteenth-century family photographs

More than a meal

Across Southeast Asian tourist cities, small host-led dining experiences have become one alternative to standard restaurant itineraries, partly as a reaction to the homogenisation of tourist restaurant culture, partly because cities like Malacca, Penang and Chiang Mai have accumulated enough long-term foreign residents with interesting lives and good kitchens to sustain it. What distinguishes Ayako's Place from most is not the food alone, or even the heirlooms. It is the sense, which guests describe repeatedly in their reviews, of being received as a person rather than served as a customer.

In online posts, visitors repeatedly describe the experience as closer to visiting relatives than eating out. One said the dinner lasted so long that leaving became difficult; another called it the most memorable meal of the trip.

A late-night poetry lesson

Later in the evening — past eleven, the lane outside quiet — Ayako brings out a notebook and reads a poem she wrote that morning. She has been writing in English only recently, encouraged by an Australian professor who told her that grammar is less important than the image, that what matters is something real passing from writer to reader.

She asks if any guests want to try. Most do. She reads each attempt with seriousness, finds something in each one to name. She is not indulging anyone. She is teaching.

This, it turns out, is what Ayako's Place is really offering: the experience of being taken seriously by people who have had, and thought carefully about, a great deal of life.

Peter was born in 1945. He says that until he was ten or so, he was often hungry — a fact he connects, with characteristic enthusiasm, to a theory he has about longevity genes and periods of scarcity. Ayako, who has heard the theory many times, listens as though it is still interesting. He is eighty. She is in her seventies. The stairs to their dining room are steep. Some months, the bookings are few.

"We are very happy here," Ayako says. "So."

That so carries considerable weight. It is the so of someone who has moved through enough of the world to know the difference between restlessness and peace, and who has chosen, deliberately, the latter.

Before guests leave — and leaving takes time, because there are small ceramic animals to press into hands, photographs to be taken, one more question always needing to be asked — Peter offers a thought that he says has been on his mind lately:

"When you are born, people are so happy. But you have no chance to recognise it. You don't know it."

He means, perhaps, that the happiness surrounding a life is only legible from inside it, over time. That recognition is the work of years.

The door at the bottom of the stairs opens onto the lane. The night is warm and close. A mosque clock somewhere chimes the quarter-hour. The shophouse behind has gone dark. There is still no sign on the door.



The room after dinner, still holding the night's stories